

LEVEL 2 . HARTWELL GROUP

Inside the day at Hartwell Group.

Director EA . Tuesday morning . 75-minute assessment

Scenarios rotate. The day described here is illustrative. The version a candidate actually sits may not be the one shown.

Hartwell Group is the scenario at the heart of EA Hire Level 2, the altitude where a career EA either graduates into the real job or stalls. This briefing describes the day-shape, the principal, and the move that defines the senior EA: the shift from execution to anticipation. Test mechanics stay confidential. Everything below is what a buyer or candidate can see.

THE MORNING

Tuesday, 09:20. You are at the desk before he is. He has just walked in, fifteen minutes late, and the door is already shut. He is writing a recommendation letter the CEO has asked him to draft. He has told you, on the way past, to hold all calls, no drop-ins, no exceptions. Outside that door, twelve emails are waiting in an inbox that has been building since before eight, and four of them are about to start moving.

THE FIRM

Hartwell Group is a UK property developer with a £2.4 billion portfolio across London and the South East: residential, commercial, mixed-use. Around three hundred staff. Founded in 2001 by CEO Patrick Sherwood and grown through opportunistic acquisition, planning uplift and build-to-rent strategy. The culture moves at the pace of the deal pipeline. Decisions happen quickly. Stakeholders are demanding. The expectation on the people supporting Directors is that they operate several steps ahead.

THE PRINCIPAL

Nathan Carr, Director of Development. Brilliant with clients. An instinct for deals others miss. Also chaotic, reactive under pressure, and the kind of principal who leaves half-finished instructions in his wake on the assumption that the people around him will fill them in. You are the person who fills them in. He trusts your judgement. He doesn't always tell you what you need to know, and the assessment tests whether you can read what he hasn't said.

LEVEL 2 . CONTINUED**THE INSTRUCTION THAT ISN'T A RULE**

The hold-all-calls instruction Nathan gave you on the way to his office is one of the load-bearing pieces of the morning. It looks like a rule. It is not a rule. It is a context. The candidate who treats it as a rule and the candidate who treats it as a context will have very different mornings.

FOUR THINGS ALREADY ALIVE

The CFO is waiting on Nathan to sign Q2 accounts before the board pack prints at four. The structural engineer on a live Phase 2 site has flagged a horizontal crack in a retaining wall, with the careful note that he would call it a moderate concern, not an emergency. The contractor on Docklands has served formal notice that an overdue invoice (£340k, forty-seven days outstanding) will stop works on Wednesday morning unless cleared funds or a confirmed payment date are in hand. The CEO's EA has emailed to flag that Patrick is expecting Nathan at Friday's leadership offsite.

THE QUIETER LAYER

Nathan's wife has emailed about Saturday dinner. The planning lead has a Friday deadline that is about to move forward. Before the morning is out, the CEO will put down whatever is in front of him and call directly. You will need to handle that call without throwing Nathan under a bus, without sounding rude to the CEO's EA, and without breaking the no-exceptions instruction in a way that loses Nathan's trust. There is no rule for any of this. There is only the room, and what you read in it.

THE 10:30 SQUEEZE

The day will accelerate. Somewhere around half past ten, three things will arrive on you inside a sixty-second window. The CFO physically waiting for you to bring Nathan to her office. Nathan walking out with an instruction for a printout in twenty minutes. The planning lead surfacing a deadline that wasn't on the diary an hour earlier. Each is reasonable in isolation. Together they are a judgement test. The question is not which one you do first. It is which one you recognise as the highest commercial weight, which one you fast-path to delegation, and which one you give a concrete slot today rather than a promise.

WHAT IS BEING TESTED

The move that defines the senior career EA: the shift from execution to anticipation. From doing what the principal told you, to doing what the principal would have told you if they had thought about it. From triage to room-reading. From rules to judgement. The four-to-eight-year EA who can make this move is the one who saves a Director time. The one who cannot is the one a Director has to walk through every decision, and that is expensive. Pillar weighting at L2: Acuity 30%, Prioritisation 30%, Execution 25%, Communication 15%.

WHAT THE REPORT TELLS THE EMPLOYER

Fourteen to sixteen pages, scored against the L2 v1.2 rubric (which now folds AI Fluency in as an emerging expectation at this altitude), reviewed by a named EA expert, delivered within 48 hours. Reference-ready extracts on request.

LEVEL 2 . SECTOR POSITIONING

How this reads against your sector.

The Hartwell scenario is set inside a property developer. The L2 altitude, the rubric and the four-pillar weighting do not change with sector. What changes is the principal's tempo, the stakeholder set, and the surface texture of the decisions. Here is how Level 2 reads in three other common contexts.

L2 IN ASSET MANAGEMENT

Picture a portfolio manager at a long-only fund. The EA holds the diary against the rhythm of market hours and earnings releases. The stakeholders include the head of research, sell-side analysts, the COO, the compliance officer, and a roster of LP-facing IR people. The discretion bar is high because portfolio holdings touch confidentiality at every turn. The Hartwell test of room-reading translates directly. A candidate who triages on urgency tokens alone will treat a sell-side analyst's polite call the same as a compliance officer's polite call, and that is a serious mistake at this altitude.

L2 IN A TECH SCALE-UP AT SERIES C

Picture a Chief Revenue Officer or Chief Operating Officer in a hundred-and-fifty-person SaaS business about to extend a Series C. The EA owns the leadership cadence: weekly one-to-ones with the CEO, monthly board updates, a constant flow of investor diligence sessions. The pace is faster than Hartwell, the language more product-oriented, the rooms on Zoom rather than in person. The L2 muscle is identical. The room-reading test bites at exactly the same place. When the principal says hold everything, can the candidate distinguish between a routine product issue (hold) and a signed term sheet appearing in the inbox (interrupt).

L2 IN A SENIOR-PARTNER PROFESSIONAL SERVICES SEAT

Picture a senior partner inside a top-tier law firm or a Big Four practice. The EA holds the diary against billing cycles and client deadlines. The internal politics are partnership politics. The CFO equivalent is the firm's risk and compliance function. The structural-engineer equivalent is a partner flagging a late-stage issue inside a transaction. The Hargreaves equivalent is a regulator's letter sitting on the desk for three days too long. Names and cadence change. Pillar weighting and L2 register stay exactly the same.

COMMISSION THE ASSESSMENT

EA Hire L2 is £495 +VAT per candidate. Briefing form returns the same working day. First report in 48 hours. Commission at thecorestandard.co.uk/ea-hire.